

Academic Writing

Lesson 3: Nominalisation



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Nominalisation: Task 1



Which text looks more 'academic' to you?

Version 1 is closer to academic writing generally than version 2.

Why?

Version 1 contains many nouns; version 2 contains more verbs and adjectives.

Why does this happen?

Academics treat phenomena as objects of discussion, analysis and evaluation. Using nouns represents phenomena as *things* (rather than actions or descriptions) means they can be discussed more robustly and clearly.

Definition & Passive Comparison



Nominalizations are **nouns** that are created from **adjectives** (words that describe nouns) **verbs** (action words) and **adverbs** (words that describe verbs).

For instance, “**scepticism**” is a nominalization of “**sceptical**”
“**decision**” is a nominalization of “**decide**”; and “**clarity**” of
“**clearly**”.

While the passive focuses on a process or an important aspect of a sentence as well as hide distractions (such as unnecessary agents), Nominalisation takes it further: it turns a whole action into some**thing** that can be talked about.

Task 2: Nominalisation



Add the missing words to the paragraph:

The **evolution** of life has been driven in part by **variation** in the physical environment. No single kind of living thing can perform well in all environments. The differences among living things that enable them to live in different kinds of environments and adopt different lifestyles are called **adapptions**.

For a long period of time, there was no life on Earth. Then there was an extended period of only uni-cellular life, followed by a **proliferation** of multi-cellular life. In other words, the nature and diversity of life has changed over time. **Identification** of the processes that result in biological **diversification** was one of the great scientific advances of the nineteenth century.

Nominalisation: Mechanics



‘Of’

There are two ways to make noun phrases. One is using “of”. See below:

*In order to **engage the public successfully**, it is essential for the media to communicate climate risks clearly.*

The **successful engagement of the public** is essential for the media to communicate climate risks clearly.

Clustering/Compounding

The other way is to cluster nouns together:

*In order to **engage** the **public successfully**, it is essential for the media to **communicate climate risks clearly**.*

Clear climate risk communication from the media is essential for **successful public engagement**.

The original is 18 words; the nominalised one is 13. Compounded nominalisations often save a large number of words, but try not to overdo them (they can get too complex).

Nominalisation: Task 3



1: Global temperatures continue to **rise rapidly**, a trend that scientists consider deeply **concerning**.

The rapid rise in global temperatures is a trend of deep concern to scientists.

2: Individuals frequently **assume** that climate change is too **complex** and **remote** to affect them personally. Therefore, many **fail** to act.

Individuals' assumptions regarding the complexity and remoteness of climate change often lead to a failure to act.

3: Because scientists have observed the **atmosphere's carbon dioxide** levels **increasing rapidly**, they are **recommending** that emissions be cut **urgently**.

Rapid atmospheric carbon dioxide increases have prompted urgent emissions cut recommendations.

4: Governments have not **communicated** the risks **clearly**, so the public does not **understand** that acting is **urgent** in this situation.

The Government's lack of communicative clarity has resulted in low public understanding of the urgency of the situation.

5: In order to **reduce** global **emissions successfully**, it is essential for governments to **invest** in **renewable energy rapidly**.

Rapid renewable energy investment is essential for successful emissions reduction.

6: The media rarely **explains** why climate policies **fail**, which makes the public **sceptical**.

The lack of clear media explanation of the failure of climate policies has caused public scepticism.

Drafting



Continue drafting your assignment for the remainder of the lesson.

